FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The batsman usually corners all the glory in cricket, cutting a swashbuckling, gladiatorial figure at the crease. The cameras love his eye-catching array of shots. Even a newbie understands the currency of fours and sixes. The Twenty20 format is designed to produce a glut of it. With shortened boundaries and fielding restrictions, it's batsmanship on steroids. Bowlers are often reduced to supporting characters, present mainly to absorb the punishment. But India now boasts a singular exception to this rule. Jasprit Bumrah is the kind of bowler who comes along once in a generation—if you are lucky. Sublime proof is at hand almost every time he runs in to bowl. We saw it again on March 8, during the T20 World Cup final, as he ran a wizard's spell around New Zealand's batting lineup. There were other reasons why India bagged its eighth ICC trophy that night. Among them, a new batting credo built around unflagging aggression, a limitless arsenal of big hitters, and a resurgent Sanju Samson rising from the ashes, in smouldering form. A greater sense of history, however, beckons us. We have put only one bowler on the cover before today. That was Anil Kumble. It's time again.

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For, Bumrah is a phenomenon bigger than the age he plays in. In one decade, he has become the first and only bowler in cricket history to reach—at various points in his career—the No. 1 ranking in all three formats. An incredible feat, given how divergent the challenges are for a bowler. Captain Suryakumar Yadav calls him "a national treasure". World-wide, his peers and predecessors say he not only towers above the rest in contemporary cricket, but he also joins the ranks of all-time greats. "Everyone else is mortal. There's good bowlers, there's great bowlers, then there's Jasprit Bumrah," says former England pacer Steve Finn. His compatriot Stuart Broad thinks Bumrah is the greatest quick bowler of all time. Even the likes of Dennis Lillee, Glenn McGrath, Waqar Younis, Wasim Akram, Dale Steyn and James Anderson overflow with praise.

It's because his artistry defies all constraints of format. In Tests, batsmen can avoid risk; the bowler has to prise open defences. In T20s, it's the bowler who is compelled to be risk-averse. But when Bumrah comes loping on his short, gazelle-like sprint, everything else seems to become irrelevant. Each ball of his can be a loitering munition, changing course across an infinitude of trajectories, all subtly different except for the end result: a likely wicket. A treat on both the visual and mental planes, as if we are watching a chess grandmaster in the guise of an athlete.

Statistics don't capture the essence of this. He can crank up the pace, beyond 150 kmph, but his real speed is that of the mind. It's his strategic awareness, the way he plots out tactics on the go, that allows him to outthink batsmen even before an inning. "I saw how New Zealand was bowling. That when you are trying to bowl too fast, the shot-making gets easier," he said after the final. So, he decided to "keep changing the pace". But intent alone does not suffice when there's zero margin for error. With Bumrah, precise control over execution turns him into a lethal weapon even in a format set up as a death trap for bowlers.

T20 bowling often borders on negative tactics. But you don't see Bumrah resort to 'almost wide' balls. Why should he, when he can send in yorkers that came straight out of geometry class? Thrice in that final, he rattled the stumps with those. In a match that saw 414 runs, peppered with 27 sixes, Bumrah gave away only 15 runs! At 3.75 runs per over. Across the Cup, a "six-hitting fest" even by T20 standards, his economy rate was 6.21. In the 2024 Cup, it was 4.17. That also hides a story about wicket records. With batsmen forced to remain on constant vigil against him, the risk shifts to the other end, and that is often where the wickets fall.

Our cover story this week gets you to the person behind the stardom: the son of a single mother who grew up in a modest home in Ahmedabad, the quiet boy who defied the early advice of coaches to change his action, the young star who had to persevere despite injury. A companion piece tells the story of the world-beating XI he was part of. This was an India team primed to a new philosophy. Gone was the old reliance on one or two big batsmen. Instead, we had a posse of batters who could keep up a relentless blitz right down to No. 9. It was an Indian variation of England's 'bazball', ultimately derived from a strategy innovated by New Zealand back in the 1992 ODI World Cup. As luck would have it, New Zealand was to be its victim on this day. Coach Gautam Gambhir talked of a 'high risk, high reward' approach. What breathed life into it was a bunch of effervescent players: Ishan Kishan, Suryakumar Yadav, Sanju Samson, Axar Patel, Hardik Pandya. Some of them had a point to prove. We tell the story of how each one did so flamboyantly, making the whole greater than the sum of its parts.

(Aroon Purie)